

The Human Abstract



POEM TEXT

- 1 Pity would be no more
- 2 If we did not make somebody poor;
- 3 And Mercy no more could be
- 4 If all were as happy as we.
- 5 And mutual fear brings peace,
- 6 Till the selfish loves increase;
- 7 Then Cruelty knits a snare,
- 8 And spreads his baits with care.
- 9 He sits down with holy fears,
- 10 And waters the ground with tears;
- 11 Then Humility takes its root
- 12 Underneath his foot.
- 13 Soon spreads the dismal shade
- 14 Of Mystery over his head;
- 15 And the caterpillar and fly
- 16 Feed on the Mystery.
- 17 And it bears the fruit of Deceit,
- 18 Ruddy and sweet to eat;
- 19 And the raven his nest has made
- 20 In its thickest shade.
- 21 The Gods of the earth and sea
- 22 Sought thro' Nature to find this tree;
- 23 But their search was all in vain:
- 24 There grows one in the Human brain.



SUMMARY

There wouldn't be any need for pity if human beings hadn't created poverty, and mercy wouldn't be necessary if everyone was as happy as those who have the means to share their fortune.

And peace only holds as long as people are afraid of each other; it breaks as soon as people's selfish desires get out of hand. Then Cruelty fashions a trap and painstakingly arranges his bait.

He sits down, modeling reverence and awe, and spills tears on the ground. Religious modesty then begins to spread its roots

beneath him.

And overhead, the dreary shadow of religious mystery spreads out like branches, and parasites start to live off it.

This tree grows a fruit made of lies, which appears healthy on the surface and tastes sweet. And the raven has built a nest in the darkest corners of the tree's canopy.

The gods of land and sea searched through all of nature for this tree, but couldn't find it, for it resides in the human brain.



THEMES



ORGANIZED RELIGION AND SUFFERING

In "The Human Abstract," Blake explores the danger of religious ideas concerning good and evil.

According to the poem's [allegory](#), traditional Christian virtues such as "Pity" and "Mercy" exist only because humanity has created poverty and unhappiness; likewise, "peace" only exists as long as people are afraid of one another. Thus, by creating virtue, human beings have also created vice. In doing so, they have ensured the spread of "Cruelty," which the poem compares to a tree taking root and casting "thickest shade" over everything. The tree, an [allusion](#) to the biblical Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, can be found nowhere in nature—it exists only in "The Human Brain." Thus, the poem depicts organized religion as the product of human faults, not divine wisdom, and as a source of suffering rather than a cure for it.

Good and evil don't exist in nature, the poem argues, but are created by the human intellect. According to the speaker, "The Gods of the earth and sea" looked everywhere in "Nature" for the [metaphorical](#) "Tree" that was the root of all human suffering. But it didn't exist out in the natural world; instead, it grew "in the Human Brain." In other words, human ideas about morality aren't real the way grass and mountains and water and food are real. They're made up! Humans decide what is virtuous, then structure their entire lives and realities around these constructed beliefs about what is good and bad.

And since morality can't exist without immorality, religious dogma is bound to create a breeding ground for "Cruelty." The speaker argues that without poverty, there would be no need for "Pity." That is, in order for people to show compassion to the less fortunate, there first has to be inequality. Likewise, the speaker points out that "Mercy" would be unnecessary if everyone were "happy." Again, inequality and oppression have to exist in order for those with money and power to prove how kind and generous they are. In an equitable world, everyone

would already have their needs met! Similarly, the speaker states that “mutual fear brings peace.” This implies that people refrain from fighting each other only because they are afraid of losing. But secretly their “selfish loves increase,” suggesting that such false harmony can only ever be temporary, since people are still driven by greed rather than goodwill toward one another.

Thus, the very traits religion traditionally conceives as the opposite of “Cruelty” allow it to set its “snare” (or trap) in the first place. The speaker personifies Cruelty as a figure who makes a show of “holy fears,” sheds crocodile “tears,” and seems to sow “Humility.” In Blake’s view, then, “holy,” pious attitudes are products of a hypocritical cruelty. And from this false humility comes the “Mystery” of religion—the whole system of myths and rituals designed to awe and captivate followers. Blake describes a “Caterpillar and Fly” who parasitically “Feed” off this system: a metaphor for all the clergy and other figures empowered by religion.

The poem thus warns against the dangers of organized religion, which the speaker sees as an unnatural source of suffering. Although the “fruit” of religion may be “Ruddy” (or healthy in appearance) “and sweet to eat,” it is the “fruit of Deceit”—that is, it’s deeply false. The speaker also cautions that its branches house “the Raven” and “his nest.” Since ravens are commonly associated with death, Blake’s image again suggests that religion, despite its wholesome appearance, only breeds destruction. In all these ways, the poem responds to and builds on Blake’s poem “The Divine Image,” from his earlier collection *Songs of Innocence*. That poem argues that “Mercy, Pity, Peace, and Love” are universal human (and, at the same time, divine!) values that transcend any one religion.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-24



HUMANITY AND THE POWER OF IDEAS

Though “The Human Abstract” cautions against the danger of abstract ideas such as “Pity” and “Mercy,” it also highlights the power of the human mind to counter that danger. Unlike the rest of nature, human beings live in a reality of their own construction. A single idea can take “root” and “spread[]” throughout not only one mind, but the whole of humanity, restructuring the entire world in its image. The poem uses the [metaphor](#) of a giant tree casting its “shade” of “Mystery,” suggesting just how delusional and confusing human reality can be. Of course, if thought has the power to shape reality, it also has the power to liberate people from that reality; this process begins when people question the very beliefs that hold them captive.

The poem’s title calls attention to the uniquely human capacity

for “Abstract” thinking, suggesting that the ability to think conceptually is what sets people apart from the rest of nature. “The earth and sea” don’t project ideas about what is good or bad or right or wrong onto the world; only “Human[s]” do that.

The poem lays out the pitfalls and “snare[s]” of conceptual thinking, while also suggesting that “The Human Brain” contains the antidote to its own suffering. In the speaker’s telling, human “Cruelty” manufactures a worldview (a theology or philosophy) out of “fear” and “selfish[ness].” Once this way of thinking takes hold, it expands like a growing tree and “spreads [its] dismal shade / Of Mystery” over the world. That “the Caterpillar and the Fly / Feed on the Mystery” might imply that this system of ideas becomes real enough to empower its adherents (e.g., clergy). Ideas may not be real in the same way bugs are real, but once they take root, they have a tangible impact on everything around them.

The speaker claims that this particular idea-tree “bears the fruit of Deceit,” and that its “thickest shade” makes a home for “the Raven,” a [symbol](#) of death. Though ideas are intangible, they can still cause immense suffering and destruction. Indeed, it’s their very “Mystery” that makes them so powerful: once they’ve expanded enough, it can be hard to pinpoint their source or their exact effects on the world. People begin to act as if these ideas are unequivocal truths rather than something human beings made up! But while bad ideas can trap us in a suffocating reality, the poem subtly hints that better ones can free us from it. Ideas are only powerful if they remain unchallenged. In general, solving human problems requires attacking the misconceptions that created them.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 5-24



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-4

*Pity would be no more
If we did not make somebody poor;
And Mercy no more could be
If all were as happy as we.*

In “The Human Abstract,” William Blake essentially summarizes human nature. More specifically, he criticizes what he sees as one of the root causes of humanity’s suffering: the corruption and hypocrisy of organized religion. (Blake was particularly critical of the Church of England, which was England’s dominant religion during his era.)

The speaker begins with the pointed observation: “Pity would be no more / If we did not make somebody poor.” In the Christian tradition, pity—the mix of sorrow and compassion one feels when confronted with another’s suffering—is

considered a Christian virtue. Yet the speaker's statement suggests that pity can only exist in response to poverty: if the world were more equitable, there would be no need of it. In this way, organized religions like Christianity *need* poverty and suffering to exist so that believers can prove their virtuousness.

The speaker then follows this statement with a [parallel](#) claim:

And Mercy no more could be
If all were as happy as we.

The [repetition](#) ("no more," "If") and parallelism bridging the poem's first two sentences emphasize that both are illustrating the same idea. We can only show "Mercy" to those we have the power to punish. If everyone had equal access to the same resources, everyone would be "happy," and there would be no reason for either punishment or leniency. By deeming "Pity" and "Mercy" virtues, the church thus ensures that inequality will continue.

/M/ [alliteration](#) ("more," "make," "Mercy," "more") accentuates these opening lines, making them more forceful and memorable. The poem's strong didactic [tone](#), meanwhile, grabs the reader's attention and expresses the speaker's deep conviction.

"The Human Abstract" consists of six [quatrains](#), or four-line [stanzas](#), written in irregular [meter](#). Each stanza can be further divided into two [couplets](#), since the poem follows a strict AABB [rhyme scheme](#). Each couplet is syntactically self-contained (the second line of each stanza ends in a semicolon, dividing the first two lines of the stanza from the last two). As a result, the speaker's ideas are parceled out in short, clear bursts. This structure gives the poem its distinctive, measured pace and helps readers follow its assertions more easily.

LINES 5-8

*And mutual fear brings peace,
Till the selfish loves increase;
Then Cruelty knits a snare,
And spreads his baits with care.*

In the second [stanza](#), the speaker elaborates on his summary of humanity. He claims that, in the world as we know it, only "mutual fear" keeps people from fighting each other—at least until their "selfish loves" (self-interested desires) drive them to break the "peace." This claim suggests that peace born of fear isn't actually peace; it's just a temporary reprieve from conflict. In general, "peace" and "love[]" can be cynical rather than authentic. To Blake, they're especially devalued when they're enforced by religious institutions, rather than prompted by organic feeling.

All this false virtue creates a perfect breeding ground for "Cruelty," which the speaker [personifies](#) as a wily, scheming figure:

Then Cruelty knits a snare,
And spreads his baits with care.

In context, this description implies that organized, hierarchical religion is a "snare" or trap, which lures in its followers and cruelly manipulates them. The hissing [sibilance](#) of this stanza ("brings peace," "selfish loves increase," "knits a snare," "spreads his baits") evokes the snaky slyness of the church, which knowingly exploits people to its own ends.

Notice, too, the [repetition](#) of "And" at the start of lines 5 and 8. This word falls at the start of many lines in the poem and adds to the momentum and urgency of Blake's language. That momentum, in turn, evokes the way religions gain traction and power through a kind of chain reaction (one thing happens, "And" then another, and so on).

"And" [anaphora](#) also appears in some English translations of the Bible (e.g., the King James Version), so it adds to the poem's preacherly tone. (Again, Blake is an independent figure preaching in *favor* of certain Christlike values but *against* the church itself. He's not against "peace," but he is against peace imposed through fear.)

LINES 9-12

*He sits down with holy fears,
And waters the ground with tears;
Then Humility takes its root
Underneath his foot.*

Lines 9-12 elaborate on the miniature [allegory](#) begun in the previous lines. The speaker continues to [personify](#) "Cruelty" as a male figure—and describes him as outwardly "holy":

He sits down with holy fears,
And waters the ground with tears;
Then Humility takes its root
Underneath his foot.

Read allegorically (that is, [symbolically](#)), this image suggests that the leaders of religious institutions are putting on a show for their followers. Their teachings and rituals are meant to inspire "fear[]" and awe, and they shed insincere "tears" to convince the congregation that they're genuine intermediaries between God and humankind. "Water[ing] the ground with tears" might also suggest that they use the threat of suffering (e.g., punishment in hell or expulsion from the church for supposed sin or heresy) to instill "Humility" in their followers.

In a religious context, "Humility" involves submitting to God. So when the speaker warns that "Humility takes its root / Underneath [Cruelty's] foot," he's implying that organized religion actually wants people to submit to the church's authority, not God's. This surrender forms a "root" system below the church, upholding its power. The church has no power without people believing that it is their only path to God.

And by teaching mindless obedience to their doctrines, religious institutions create a power imbalance that leads to abuse and suffering—often the same kind of suffering they claim to alleviate.

LINES 13-16

*Soon spreads the dismal shade
Of Mystery over his head;
And the caterpillar and fly
Feed on the Mystery.*

Once the church's foundation—or "root" system—is in place, corruption grows into a towering, [metaphorical](#) "tree." It "Soon spreads the dismal shade / Of Mystery over [the] head" of the figure who planted it.

This "Mystery" is contrived and, again, born of "Cruelty." Religious leaders don't want their followers to understand the inner workings of the church, since the aura of mystery is part of what gives them their power. They pretend to some special, cryptic knowledge of the divine, then offer their services to others as conduits between humankind and God. In this way, "the caterpillar and fly"—metaphors for the clergy—parasitically "Feed on the Mystery." That is, they profit from people's confusion. As long as people feel lost without the guidance of the church, they help uphold the church's power and authority. The [repetition](#) of the word "Mystery" (in lines 14 and 16) emphasizes the importance of lies and illusion in this power structure.

The metaphor of the tree is evocative in part because trees' branches mirror their root systems—but while their branches are visible, their roots are not. In much the same way, devotees never see the inner workings of religious institutions, only the parts meant to hold them in thrall. Yet if the system is "root[ed]" in corruption, its outgrowths (branches, etc.) must be wicked as well. Accordingly, the "shade" of this tree isn't sheltering or pleasant; it's "dismal" and gloomy, like evil or ignorance. Religious "Mystery" doesn't comfort believers, just keeps them in the dark.

LINES 17-20

*And it bears the fruit of Deceit,
Ruddy and sweet to eat;
And the raven his nest has made
In its thickest shade.*

The fifth stanza continues to develop the [extended metaphor](#) comparing organized religion to a "tree."

The speaker describes the "fruit" of this tree as "Ruddy" (reddish or healthy-looking) "and sweet to eat." The [internal rhyme](#) between "sweet" and "eat" emphasizes the attractiveness of organized religion and the sway it holds over many people. The church provides a sense of wholesomeness to its followers; their devotion and piety makes them feel good about themselves. Yet the speaker believes its fruit, or output,

is "Deceit[ful]"—intentionally misleading.

While people are distracted by the church's glossy illusions, a "raven" makes himself at home in the "thickest shade" of the tree. [Symbolizing](#) death and wickedness, the shadowy raven suggests that the church's public face and its real aims have nothing in common, and that unquestioning obedience to religious dogma has devastating effects. History is littered with examples of religious hypocrisy and corruption, and the poem suggests this is an inevitable result of religious institutions wielding so much power.

Of course, the tree's "sweet [fruit]" also serves as an [allusion](#) to the Biblical story of Adam and Eve and the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. According to the Bible, God created Adam and Eve and let them roam free in the idyllic Garden of Eden. They were allowed to eat from any tree except the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil—but the Devil tempted Eve, who tasted the fruit of this tree and shared it with Adam. The fruit made them conscious of their own nakedness, and for the first time, they felt shame. This event introduced sin into the world, and in punishment, God cast Adam and Eve out of the Garden. The allusion seems to indict the rigid moral doctrines of Christianity, implying that wickedness comes not from *disobeying* arbitrary rules, but rather *creating* them in the first place.

LINES 21-24

*The Gods of the earth and sea
Sought thro' Nature to find this tree;
But their search was all in vain:
There grows one in the Human brain.*

The poem's final [stanza](#) brings its [extended metaphor](#), and its [allegory](#), to a close.

According to the speaker, "The Gods of the earth and sea" have "Sought thro[ugh] Nature" for the [metaphorical](#) "tree" religion creates, only to find their efforts "all in vain." The tree exists nowhere in nature, only "in the Human brain." In other words, there's nothing organic about organized religion or strict, petty moral rules. These things are designed by human beings—not to make the world a better place, but to dominate other people and profit from their misfortune.

The reference to "Gods of the earth and sea" implies, of course, that nature isn't *devoid* of divinity. Blake was an intensely spiritual writer, so he isn't arguing against an ethical or spiritual world, but rather against religious institutions that treat people like cogs in a machine. The Church of England (any many other religions throughout history) imposed harsh moral laws and forbade questioning or disagreeing with its doctrines. The poem suggests that people don't need these kind of black-and-white rules to cultivate real virtue—that, in fact, real virtue can't exist in a punitive, hierarchical, conformist system.

The fact that these harmful ideas grow "in the Human brain"

also suggests, however, that human beings already have everything they need to dismantle the harmful systems they've created. If the mind is powerful enough to dream up clever forms of "Cruelty," it's also powerful enough to imagine and create a better world.



SYMBOLS



THE RAVEN

Ravens often [symbolize](#) evil and death, and this is certainly true in "The Human Abstract." The speaker describes this bird making "his nest" in the "thickest shade" of the [metaphorical](#) religion-"tree." The "shade" of this tree isn't refreshing but "dismal"; it leaves people in the darkness of "Mystery" and ignorance. And while the tree's "fruit" appears healthy and tastes "sweet," its virtues are illusions.

All this suggests that, rather than improving people's lives, organized religion breeds "Deceit." It overshadows truth and creates vast suffering. That the raven builds its "nest" in this setting implies that evil readily finds a home under the obfuscating mysticism of religion. "Cruelty" is the only thing that thrives where strict rules about morality prevail.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- **Lines 19-20:** "And the raven his nest has made / In its thickest shade"



POETIC DEVICES

EXTENDED METAPHOR

The poem uses the [extended metaphor](#) of a "tree" to describe the spread of human "Cruelty" in the form of organized religion.

The speaker starts by depicting Cruelty as a figure who "knits a snare" with religious posturing, after which "Humility takes it root / Underneath his foot." This image suggests that people use religion to control and oppress others, since the supposed "Humility" (here meaning pious submission to a deity) occurs beneath Cruelty's foot. These tears of false piety water the [figurative](#) tree, which grows massive and "Soon spreads the dismal shade / Of Mystery" all over the world.

This isn't *mystery* in a good sense; it refers to the methods by which religion entralls its followers. Its looming presence casts a miserable shadow on everything, and "the caterpillar and fly" ([metaphors](#) for the clergy who live off the church) survive by "Feed[ing] on" it. And while its "fruit" appears wholesome and delicious, that's just a "Deceit[ful]" illusion: the tree is poison. Hence, "the raven" (a [symbol](#) of death and evil)

makes its home in the "thickest shade" of the tree. This image suggests that the spread of organized religion is also the spread of mayhem, ignorance, and corruption—and that once the problem has "take[n] root," it can be hard to see clearly how it operates and to what ends.

The speaker exposes the reality of this tree (i.e., of religion) by explaining that it grows "in the Human Brain," not in "Nature." Laws about morality don't exist in the natural world; people make them up, and according to Blake, they cause more suffering than they're worth.

Where Extended Metaphor appears in the poem:

- Lines 7-24

PERSONIFICATION

The speaker [personifies](#) "Cruelty" as a male figure who gains power by "snar[ing]" others with religious "baits." In other words, he uses false piety—"sit[ting] down with holy fears" and crying performative "tears"—to lure people toward the doctrines of formal religion. In reality, he wants to capture the "root" of religion, "Humility" (as in submission to a higher power), under his own oppressive "foot." He doesn't actually want believers to submit to *God*, that is, but to himself—and to a set of ideas he can use to manipulate them.

That this small "root" soon causes the "shade / Of Mystery" to extend "over his head" suggests how quickly and uncontrollably such ideas can spread. In the larger context of the poem, this [imagery](#) implies that organized religion—and the injustice it creates—eventually becomes its own self-perpetuating system. Ideas start out small, but they can grow and infiltrate reality, redefining our worldview until we don't know the difference between reality and fiction.

The personification of cruelty is also a reminder that evil doesn't just happen; it's a product of "the Human Brain." Social ills, the poem implies, stem from made-up, manipulative moral rules rather than anything intrinsic to the natural world.

Where Personification appears in the poem:

- **Lines 7-14:** "Then Cruelty knits a snare, / And spreads his baits with care. / He sits down with holy fears, / And waters the ground with tears; / Then Humility takes its root / Underneath his foot. / Soon spreads the dismal shade / Of Mystery over his head;"

ALLUSION

The poem's [extended metaphor](#) about a "tree" [alludes](#) to the Bible: specifically, the Tree of the Knowledge and Good and Evil. Since the poem concerns organized religion and morality, and since Blake was outspoken in his criticisms of the Church of England, it's safe to assume this Christian reference is

deliberate.

In the Book of Genesis, God creates Adam and Eve, the first humans, and the beautiful Garden of Eden for them to live in. They are allowed to eat fruit from any tree except for the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil. But the Devil, in the form of a snake, tempts Eve to taste the fruit. Eve shares the fruit with Adam, and when they eat of it, they become aware of their own nakedness, thus introducing sin into the world. God casts Adam and Eve out of the Garden, forcing them to wander the earth in punishment for their transgression.

By alluding to this story, the poem suggests that organized religion creates corruption rather than virtue—that its "fruit," or output, is as "Deceit[ful]" as the snake in Eden. (In other words, as deceitful as the devil.) That this metaphorical tree exists only "in the Human Brain" further suggests that all of our stories about good and evil, including those in the Bible, were created by *people*, and thus should be approached with a healthy dose of skepticism.

Where Allusion appears in the poem:

- **Lines 17-24:** "And it bears the fruit of Deceit, / Ruddy and sweet to eat; / And the raven his nest has made / In its thickest shade. / The Gods of the earth and sea / Sought thro' Nature to find this tree; / But their search was all in vain: / There grows one in the Human brain."

REPETITION

[Repetition](#) helps create rhythm and emphasis throughout the poem. The first [stanza](#), for example, uses both repetition and [parallel structure](#):

Pity would be **no more**
If we did not make somebody poor;
And Mercy **no more** could be
If all were as happy as we.

The parallelism between lines 1-2 and lines 3-4 emphasizes that both of these statements are making the same point: religious virtue exists only because inequality does. People can't show "Pity" toward the "poor" if no one is poor; people can't show "Mercy" toward the unhappy if no one is unhappy. The repetition of "If" also stresses that the speaker is imagining a different world, one in which moral binaries yield to a more equitable and just society.

Though not exactly [anaphora](#), the repetition of "And" at the beginning of lines 3, 5, 8, 10, 15, 17, and 19 has an insistent quality that lends urgency to the poem's message. It also helps suggest how quickly "Cruelty" takes root and gets out of control, creating a "dismal" world through a kind of chain reaction (one thing happens, "And" another, "And" another, etc.). The effect is faintly biblical, too: the King James

translation of the Bible, for example, is full of verses that start with "And." In adopting this effect, Blake sounds as if he's trying to write his own, original scripture (a pretty fair description of his literary project in general!).

In the fourth stanza, the speaker repeats the word "Mystery" twice, highlighting the way religious leaders create a web of illusions made of complicated rules and rituals. This isn't a *natural* mystery but a contrived one, used to "Decei[ve]" people.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "no more"
- **Line 2:** "If"
- **Line 3:** "And," "no more"
- **Line 4:** "If"
- **Line 5:** "And"
- **Line 8:** "And"
- **Line 10:** "And"
- **Line 14:** "Mystery"
- **Line 15:** "And"
- **Line 16:** "Mystery"
- **Line 17:** "And"
- **Line 19:** "And"

ALLITERATION

[Alliteration](#) (along with other sonic effects, like [sibilance](#) and [assonance](#)) makes the poem more lyrical, intense, and memorable. Notice, for example, how /m/ alliteration intensifies the language of the first three lines:

Pity would be **no more**
If we did not **make** somebody poor;
And **Mercy** **no more** would be

These lines are memorable in part because of the way their sounds roll off the tongue. Memorability is especially important for a poem that is trying to combat widespread, entrenched beliefs. (Blake was trying to get people's attention and make them think critically about the church.) In a subtle way, this insistent alliteration helps establish the moral and spiritual intensity of the poem as a whole.

In the second [stanza](#), /c/ alliteration draws a strong connection between "Cruelty" and the "care" with which it's devised. (The worst cruelty, Blake suggests here, is not spontaneous but wily and premeditated.) There's also lots of sibilance in this stanza:

And mutual fear brings peace,
Till the selfish loves increase;
Then Cruelty knits a snare,
And spreads his baits with care.

The soft, snaky /s/ sounds convey the sneakiness with which

religious institutions often operate, luring people in while obscuring their real motives. The sibilance in stanza four ("Soon spreads," "dismal," "Mystery") has a similar effect, again evoking the serpentine "Deceit" of the clergy.

The poem's alliterations can create an emotional charge, too. In lines 15-17, for instance, fricative /f/ sounds ("fly"/"Feeds"/"fruit") help underline Blake's vehement anger and disgust. Here, the speaker is lamenting the "Mystery" created by confusing doctrine, and the way religion's arbitrary, deceptive rules and regulations are consumed by the unsuspecting masses.

Where Alliteration appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "more"
- **Line 2:** "make"
- **Line 3:** "Mercy," "more"
- **Line 4:** "were," "we"
- **Line 7:** "Cruelty," "snare"
- **Line 8:** "spreads," "care"
- **Line 9:** "He," "holy"
- **Line 11:** "Humility"
- **Line 13:** "Soon," "spreads"
- **Line 15:** "fly"
- **Line 16:** "Feed"
- **Line 17:** "fruit"
- **Line 18:** "Ruddy"
- **Line 19:** "raven"



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"The Human Abstract" contains 24 lines arranged into six [quatrains](#) (four-line [stanzas](#)). The neat, orderly stanzas help to organize the speaker's ideas, with each stanza illustrating the next stage of his argument. They also help to control the poem's pacing, doling Blake's argument out in small, bite-sized chunks that are easier for readers to digest.

Each stanza can be further divided into two [couplets](#) due to the poem's AABB [rhyme scheme](#). These couplets help highlight the false binaries created by religious institutions, thus emphasizing the church's hypocrisy. They also break the poem into even more approachable segments.

METER

The poem's [meter](#) is irregular. Some of its lines are written in [iambic](#) trimeter (meaning they contain six syllables that follow an unstressed-stressed rhythm: da-DUM). The second stanza generally follows this pattern:

And mut- | ual fear | brings peace,
Till the self- | ish loves | increase;
Then Cruel- | ty knits | a snare,
And spreads | his baits | with care.

The only irregularity is in line 6, which begins with an [anapest](#) (two unstressed syllables followed by one stressed: da-da-DUM). But other parts of the poem are far less regimented. Take lines 1-4, for example:

Pity | would be | no more
If we | did not make | somebod- | y poor;
And Mer- | cy no more | could be
If all | were as hap- | py as we.

Here there is a mixture of iambs, anapests, and trochees (stressed-unstressed feet: DUM-da). There are typically three accented syllables per line, even as the rhythm and syllable count varies, so the poem's meter could be described as three-beat accentual meter. But even this pattern is approximate, since the second line here contains *four* accented syllables (as does line 22 later in the poem).

The poem's irregular meter seems to reflect Blake's rejection of rigid religious doctrine. In order to resist the "snare" of this kind of thinking, one has to be flexible and alert, and the poem's shifting rhythms help evoke this flexibility.

RHYME SCHEME

The poem follows a basic AABB [rhyme scheme](#), with each [quatrain](#) consisting of two [couplets](#). The simplicity of this



VOCABULARY

Abstract () - In this context, "Abstract" primarily means summary; "The Human Abstract," then, is an overview of human nature or the human condition. But the word can also mean "theoretical" or "conceptual," as in the kinds of abstract concepts explored in the poem ("Pity," "Mercy," etc.).

Mutual (Line 5) - Reciprocal; experienced or shared by everyone involved.

Snare (Line 7) - A trap.

Baits (Line 8) - Food or other lures used to attract victims to a trap.

Humility (Line 11) - While *Humility* generally describes a state of being humble or modest, it has a slightly different meaning in religious contexts, where it specifically suggests submission to a deity.

Dismal (Line 13) - Dreary and pitiful.

Deceit (Line 17) - Dishonesty; deception or manipulation of others.

Ruddy (Line 18) - Reddish and healthy-looking.

Thro' (Line 22) - An old-fashioned contraction of "through."

scheme gives the poem an almost childlike, nursery-rhyme-like quality, which makes its claims about organized religion feel more memorable and direct. In some cases, the couplets also highlight conceptual or thematic links between rhyme words, such as the connection between "fears" and "tears" (meaning pious awe and sorrow) in lines 9-10.

Most of the [end rhymes](#) are exact ("more"/"poor," "be"/"we," etc.), but there are a series of [slant rhymes](#) in the middle of the poem (lines 11-16: "root"/"foot," "shade"/"head," and "fly"/"Mystery"). These imperfect rhymes coincide with the passage about religion's false "Humility" and deceptive "Mystery," so they might subtly reflect the imperfections of religion itself.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

William Blake (1757-1827) is revered as one of the most unique and influential figures in the history of English literature. Though he is now often considered the first of the [Romantic](#) poets, thanks to his ideals regarding nature, the imagination, and creativity, he was considered peculiar and even deranged in his own time. Unlike contemporaries such as [Samuel Taylor Coleridge](#) and [William Wordsworth](#), he struggled to find an audience—either popular or critical—that understood or appreciated his work.

In part, this was due to the visionary quality of Blake's poetry. From early childhood on, Blake spoke of witnessing angels and other spiritual phenomena, and these experiences informed his work so profoundly that even Coleridge, himself a visionary, [remarked](#) that he was quite "common-place" compared to Blake.

Blake published "The Human Abstract" in his 1794 book *Songs of Innocence and Experience*, which expanded on his prior 1789 collection, *Songs of Innocence*. As a whole, this two-part collection explores the contrasting sides of human nature, and can be seen as a re-envisioning of the Biblical tale of the Garden of Eden and humanity's fall from grace.

Blake's writing was meant to instill moral lessons, but not simple ones: the deceptively plainspoken poems of *Innocence and Experience* can be interpreted in many ways. Many of the poems in *Innocence* correspond directly with a poem in *Experience*; "The Human Abstract," for example, corresponds with "[The Divine Image](#)" (in fact, he originally titled this poem "The Human Image"). "The Divine Image" presents "Mercy, Pity, Peace, and Love" as values that connect humanity directly to God and thus transcend any single religion. "The Human Abstract" warns against the danger of trying to regulate these values, or morality in general. Notably, Blake often moved poems back and forth between the *Innocence* and *Experience* sections of the book, even after they were published, proving that these poems aren't straightforward depictions of one side of human experience or the other.

One of Blake's most important influences was John Milton, whose epic poems [Paradise Lost](#) and *Paradise Regained* influenced this poem's lost-and-found narrative. Blake revered Milton: not only did he create four different sets of illustrations for *Paradise Lost*, but he also wrote an epic poem called "Milton" in which Milton's spirit enters Blake's foot and leads him into "The City of Art." In other words, Blake credited Milton with his



SPEAKER

The speaker of "The Human Abstract" is never identified. While some poems in *Songs of Innocence and Experience* (the collection in which this poem appears) adopt the viewpoints of specific characters, this one doesn't. Since the poem's criticisms of organized religion reflect Blake's own views, the speaker might be Blake himself. But the speaker gives hardly any information about themselves, as if their personal identity is beside the point. The only exception comes in the first [stanza](#), as the speaker uses the first-person plural ("we") to suggest that they are relatively "happy" and financially stable (not "poor"). Indeed, they seem to speak on behalf of the relatively fortunate while preaching against inequality.

But they soon drop any reference to themselves, as they proceed to speak with great authority about humanity and its "Cruelty." They present their observations as unequivocal truths—for example, "Pity would be no more / If we did not make somebody poor" and "The Gods of the earth and sea / Sought thro' Nature to find this tree." This almost omniscient point of view is very didactic. The speaker intends to *teach* the reader about life—to provide them an "Abstract" (or summary) of human nature.



SETTING

The poem doesn't have a physical [setting](#), since it deals with concepts rather than the material world. It uses the [extended metaphor](#) of a "tree" to make a point about organized religion and its effect on humanity. The speaker envisions "Cruelty" as a person who sets a trap by "water[ing] the ground with tears." Through his performance of religious piety, "Humility takes its root" beneath him, while above him, the "dismal shade / Of Mystery" produces "Deceit[ful]" fruit (lies) and provides a home for "the raven" (a [symbol](#) of death and wickedness).

The speaker is quick to assert, however, that this "tree" grows in "the Human Brain" rather than "Nature." It's just an idea, or a

creativity and felt an intensely personal connection to his work.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

William Blake was a deeply religious man, but he was highly critical of *organized* religion. He was born to a family of Dissenters, a group of English Protestants who broke away from and rebelled against the Church of England (and instilled in Blake an early distrust of the religious status quo). He generally saw top-down religious structures as getting in the way of a direct relationship between humanity and God.

For that matter, he believed—and memorably said, in *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*—that "everything that lives is holy." To Blake, the whole world was infused with divinity, which people could see if only they opened their eyes to the "infinite that was hid" behind the illusions of custom and daily life. In this, he (like many of his Romantic contemporaries) rebelled against the rationalistic worldviews of 18th-century Enlightenment philosophers. He was also influenced by the revolutions (French and American) taking place around him. Seeing that political and religious systems could be dismantled and new liberties gained, Blake used his work to address social ills like [racism](#) and the [mistreatment of children](#).

The Industrial Revolution also weighed heavily on Blake's mind. He worried that human beings were losing touch with nature, and therefore with God, themselves, and one another. This poem, for example, [juxtaposes](#) the evils of organized religion with the inherent holiness of the natural world, stressing that the rigidity of religious dogma—and all the suffering it causes—stems from "the Human brain," not "Nature."



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [An Overview of British Romanticism](#) — Read the British Library's introduction to and articles about the literary movement Blake helped set in motion. (<https://www.bl.uk/romantics-and-victorians/articles/the-romantics>)
- [Songs of Innocence and Experience](#) — Look through Project Gutenberg's e-book version of Blake's literary and artistic masterpiece, including "The Human Abstract." (<https://www.gutenberg.org/files/1934/1934-h/1934-h.htm#song40>)
- [A Biography of William Blake](#) — A Poetry Foundation article on the poet's life and career. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/william-blake>)
- [The Radicalism of Blake's Printing Process](#) — A video and article discussing Blake's innovative printing technique

and why it is emblematic of his artistry.

(<https://www.openculture.com/2022/05/william-blake-the-remarkable-printing-process-of-the-english-poet-artist-visionary.html>)

- [William Blake and Religion](#) — An article examining Blake's unorthodox relationship to Christianity and organized religion in general. (<https://yalebooks.yale.edu/2016/11/02/the-artful-religion-of-william-blake/>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER WILLIAM BLAKE POEMS

- [A Dream](#)
- [Ah! Sun-flower](#)
- [A Poison Tree](#)
- [Earth's Answer](#)
- [Holy Thursday \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [Holy Thursday \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [Infant Joy](#)
- [Infant Sorrow](#)
- [Introduction \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [London](#)
- [Nurse's Song \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [Nurse's Song \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [The Chimney Sweeper \(Songs of Experience\)](#)
- [The Chimney Sweeper \(Songs of Innocence\)](#)
- [The Clod and the Pebble](#)
- [The Divine Image](#)
- [The Ecchoing Green](#)
- [The Fly](#)
- [The Garden of Love](#)
- [The Lamb](#)
- [The Little Black Boy](#)
- [The Little Vagabond](#)
- [The School Boy](#)
- [The Sick Rose](#)
- [The Tyger](#)
- [To Autumn](#)
- [To the Evening Star](#)



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